

Algorithmic choice relocates power

Research questions plus data artifacts collected (no results yet).



NO RESULTS TODAY

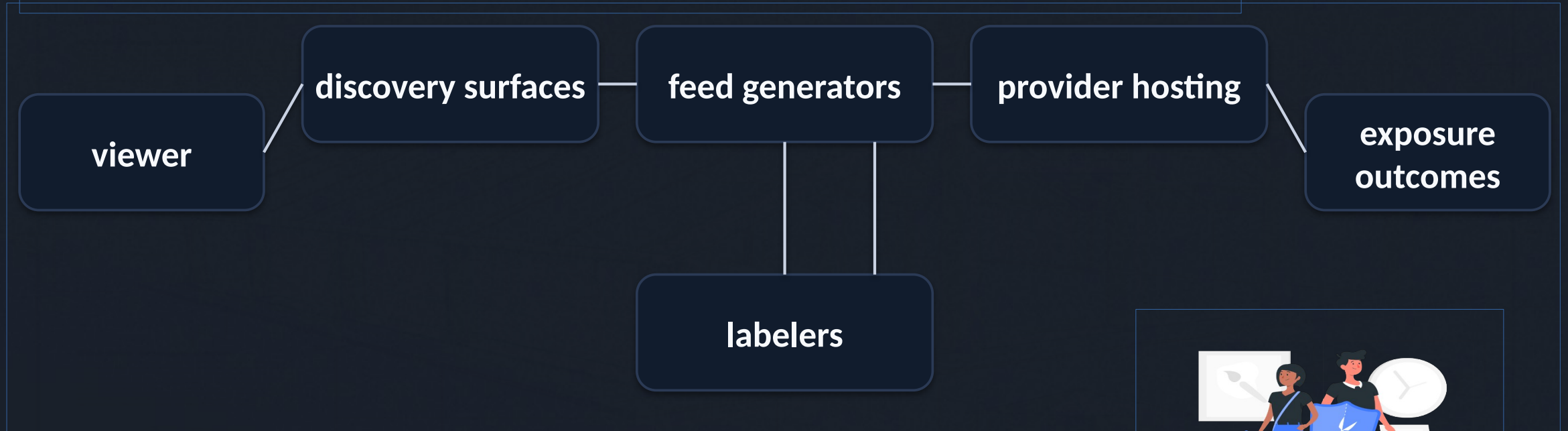
Algorithmic choice does not remove power - it relocates it.
Meeting focus: prioritize RQs and define what to recollect next.



System framing: pluggable services, new chokepoints



Takeaway: modular services relocate concentration.



Discovery surfaces and provider hosting are key chokepoints.



Bluesky UI: feed marketplace (/feeds)



Takeaway: feeds are discoverable + selectable algorithmic timelines.

A. /feeds directory

Search feeds

B. Feed cards

Creator + likes

C. Trending widget

Defaults matter

Discovery risk



Bluesky UI: what a feed looks like



Takeaway: a feed page renders an algorithm into a timeline of posts.

A. Feed name

Demand signals

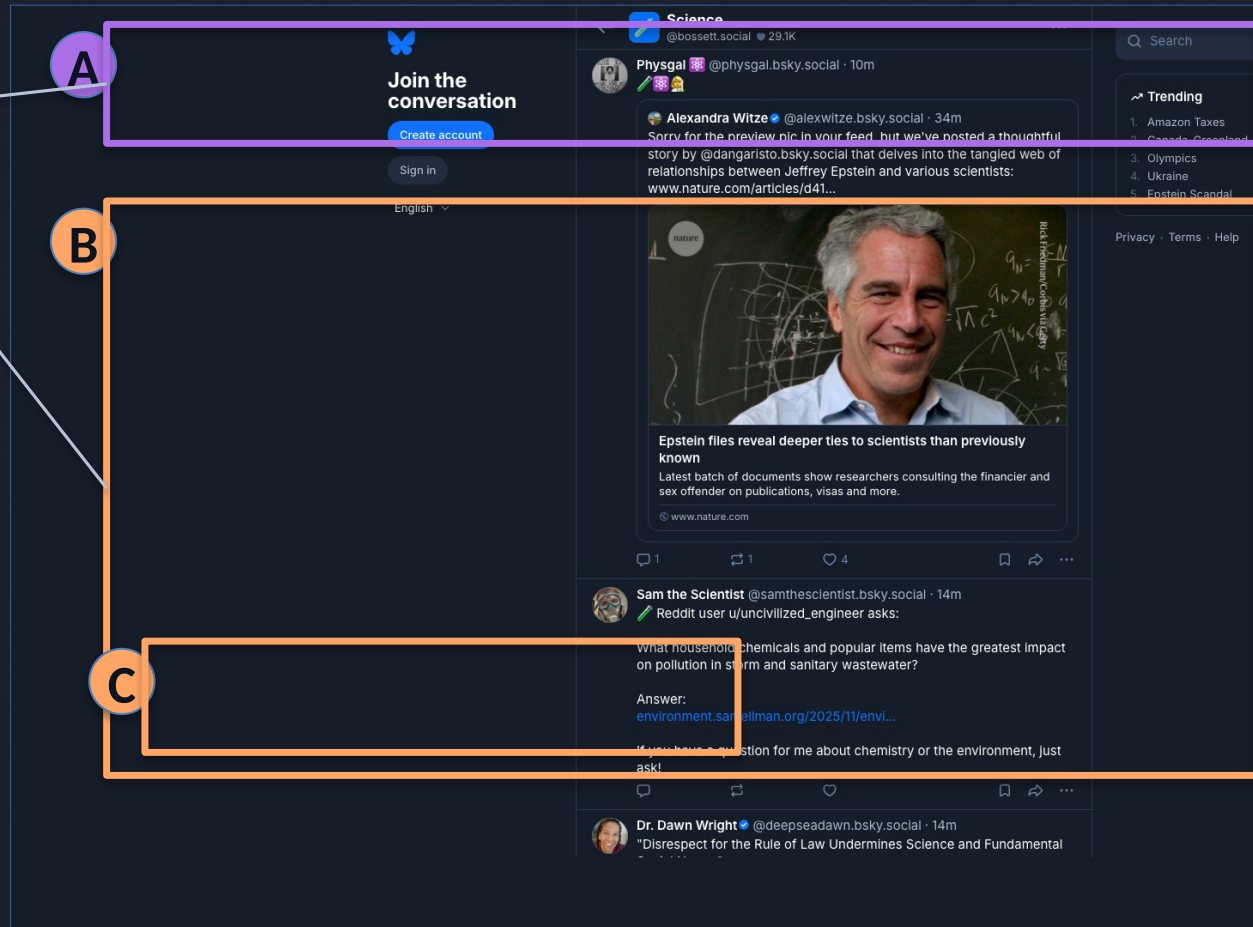
B. Timeline output

Exposure decisions

C. Post actions

Why we measure

Manipulation risk



Bluesky UI: starter packs (onboarding bundles)



Takeaway: starter packs bundle people (and sometimes feeds) for fast onboarding.

A. Pack title

Curated list

B. Join button

1-click onboarding

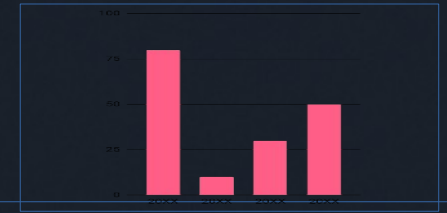
C. People cards

Curation questions

Measure exposure

The screenshot shows a Bluesky starter pack interface. At the top, a blue header bar contains the Bluesky logo (a white butterfly) and the text 'Science Minds' and 'Starter pack by @korkie.bsky.social'. Below this, a dark blue box contains the text 'A collection of credentialed scientists and scholars personally vetted by me and added to this list 1 by 1. We need access to these bright minds.' and a blue 'Join Bluesky' button. Below the button, it says '560K joined this week' and 'You'll follow these people and 60 others'. The bottom section, labeled 'C', shows a list of people cards. Each card includes a profile picture, a name, a handle, and a bio. The first card is for 'Science Friday' (@scifri.bsky.social), followed by 'Technology Connections' (@techconnectify.bsky.social), a user with a circular profile picture (@sailorrooscout.bsky.social), 'Elizabeth Jacobs, PhD' (@elizabethjacobs.bsky.social), and 'Patsy "Resistance Kitty" Evans Ph.D.' (@drharmony.net).

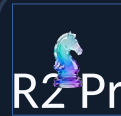
Research questions (R1-R5)



Takeaway: security and privacy scope.



R1 Discovery chokepoints? governance.



R2 Provider buckets dominate? reliability.



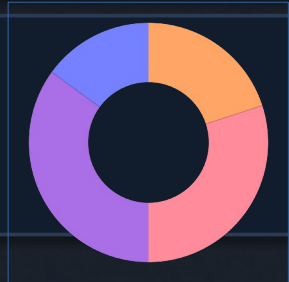
R3 Same winners across feeds? manipulation.



R4 Labels vary by viewer? safety.

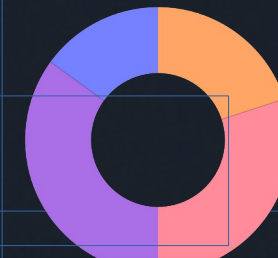


R5 Future experiment: gaming plus privacy attacks. extra guardrails.





Data artifacts collected (no results)



Discovery inputs

feed_generators_index.csv
starterpacks.csv
starterpack_feeds.csv
discovery_feed_inclusions.csv
popular_feeds.csv

Panel snapshots

feed_panel.csv
feed_items.csv.gz
posts.csv.gz
authors.csv.gz
post_labels.csv.gz

Trust and reproducibility

state.db
run_metadata.csv
run_summary.csv
manifest.csv
data_dictionary.csv
validation_report.csv

Join spine

feed_panel -> feed_items -> posts/authors
post_labels attaches by feed_uri, viewer_mode, post_uri, post_cid.
Result: joinable, reproducible, auditable artifacts.



Data receipt: discovery surfaces (starter packs + popular list)



Takeaway: discovery is measurable via starter-pack inclusion and popular list ranks.

A. Starter packs

starterpacks +
starterpack_feeds

B. Inclusion_count

slot_count (position-
weighted)

C. Popularity_rank

Why it matters

Concentration + provider
leverage

A starterpacks.csv (metadata)

name	creator_did	starterpack_uri
Interesting People	did:plc:32kt...u6sfyc	.../app.bsky.graph.starterpack/3lr2lbcjrd623

Receipt (truncated)

B starterpack_feeds.csv (inclusion)

starterpack_uri	feed_uri
.../app.bsky.graph.starterpack/3lr2lbcjrd623	.../app.bsky.feed.generator/art-new

Receipt (truncated)

C popular_feeds.csv (first row)

rank	feed_uri	collected_at_utc
1	.../app.bsky.feed.generator/whats-hot	2026-02-06T00:17:52Z

Receipt (truncated)

Data receipt: ranked exposure + risk labels



Takeaway: feed_items + posts + labels already support H1-H6 (cross-sectional).

A. feed_items row

(feed_uri, viewer_mode, rank)

B. posts row

text + links + langs

C. post_labels row

H6: risk exposure

Feed auditing / mitigations

A feed_items.csv.gz (labeled impression)

feed_uri	viewer_mode	rank	post_uri
.../app.bsky.feed.generator/homunatic	unauth	12	.../app.bsky.feed.post/3me5ms3r...
post_cid	author_did		
bafyreidlca...t63ednqvh47a	did:plc:155j...lrqx7r		

B posts.csv.gz (metadata only)

post_uri	post_cid	author_did	created_at
.../app.bsky.feed.post/3me5ms3r...	bafyreidlca...t63ednqvh47a	did:plc:155j...lrqx7r	2026-02-06T00:15:34.418Z
embed	external_domain	langs_json	
images	(none)	["en"]	

C post_labels.csv.gz (labels excerpt; Feb 1 run)

- did:plc:ar7c...vrndac:porn
- did:plc:227n...iy2skq:sexual
- did:plc:22ye...hw6pav:nudity
- did:plc:23rl...t4l754:graphic-media
- did:plc:ar7c...vrndac:self-harm
- did:plc:ar7c...vrndac:intolerant
- did:plc:ar7c...vrndac:rude
- did:plc:pa27...kcebyv:!no-unauthenticated
- did:plc:3dyb...4ws2vb:comment_count:0
- did:plc:37vi...zdr2m:reaction_count:5
- did:plc:3aqf...w4xz6v:Adult Content

Data receipt: labels (schema + global values + prefs)



Takeaway: labels are structured safety signals; behavior depends on viewer prefs.

A. Label schema

(src, uri/cid, val, neg, cts)

B. Global values

protocol-defined strings

C. Viewer prefs

hide / warn / ignore

Docs grounding

A

ATProto spec: label object fields

The fields on the label object are:

- ``ver`` (integer, required): label schema version. Current version is always ``1``.
- ``src`` (string, DID format, required): the authority (account) which generated this label
- ``uri`` (string, URI format, required): the content that this label applies to. For a specific record, an ``at://`` URI. For an account, the ``did:``.

B

Bluesky docs: global label values (excerpt)

- `!warn` which puts a generic warning on content but can be clicked through. Not configurable by the user.
- `!no-unauthenticated` which makes the content inaccessible to logged-out users in applications which respect the label.
- `porn` which puts a warning on images and can only be clicked through if the user is 18+ and has enabled adult content.
- `sexual` which behaves like `porn` but is meant to handle less intense sexual content.
- `graphic-media` which behaves like `porn` but is for violence / gore.
- `nudity` which puts a warning on images but isn't 18+ and defaults to ignore.

C

Bluesky docs: viewer preferences (hide/warn/ignore)

```
moderationPrefs: {  
  // is adult content allowed?  
  adultContentEnabled: true,  
  
  // the global label settings (used on self-labels)  
  labels: {  
    porn: 'hide',  
  },  
}
```

Data receipt: custom labels (definitions + targets)



Takeaway: labelers can define custom taxonomies; we preserve raw label_val strings.

A. Custom definitions

blur + severity + defaults

B. Label targets

account vs profile vs content

C. Observed values

dataset examples

Why it matters

A Bluesky docs: custom label values (table excerpt)

Blurs	Severity	Description
content	alert	Hide the content and put a "danger" warning label on the content if viewed
content	inform	Hide the content and put a "neutral" information label on the content if viewed

B Bluesky docs: label targets (account / profile / content)

Label targets

Labels may be placed on accounts or records. The Bluesky app interprets the targets in 3 different ways:

- On an account: has account-wide effects
- On a profile: affects only the profile record (e.g. user avatar) and never hides any content, including the account in listings.

C Feb 1 run: custom label_val strings (examples)

```
- child_comment_count:2
- comment_count:5
- reaction_count:5
- Adult Content
- child_comment_count:0
- comment_count:0
- reaction_count:2
```

Data receipt: labelers (declarations + subscriptions + self-labels)



Takeaway: labels come from services; viewers choose which labelers to trust.

A. Declaration

values + policies

A

Bluesky docs: labeler declaration (record excerpt)

```
"type": "app.bsky.labeler.service",
"policies": {
  "labelValues": ["porn", "spider"],
  "labelValueDefinitions": [
    {
      "identifier": "spider",
      "severity": "alert",
      "blurs": "media",
      "defaultSetting": "warn"
```

B. Subscriptions

viewer-selected

B

Bluesky docs: labeler subscriptions (viewer-selected)

Labeler subscriptions

To include labels from a given labeler, you set the `atproto-accept-labelers` header on the HTTP request to a comma-separated list of the DIDs of the labelers you want to include. The AppView will subscribe to the included labelers (if it hasn't already) and attach any relevant labels. It includes the `atproto-content-labelers` header in the response to indicate which labelers were successfully included.

C. Self-labels

built-in values

Why it matters

C

Bluesky docs: self-labels (supported values)

Only global labels can be used for self-labeling, but not all global labels can be used for self-labeling. The supported self-label values are:

- `!no-unauthenticated`
- `porn`
- `sexual`

Data receipt: moderation decisions (flags + UI contexts)



Takeaway: the same label can blur/warn/filter depending on context + prefs.

A. moderatePost()

post + prefs → decision

B. Output flags

filter / blur / alert /
inform

C. UI contexts

contentList vs view vs
media

Docs grounding

A Bluesky docs: moderatePost() (input → decision)

```
} from '@atproto/api'
```

Each of these follows the same API signature:

```
const res = moderatePost(post, moderationOptions)
```

B Bluesky docs: decision flags (filter / blur / alert / inform)

The response object provides an API for figuring out what your UI should do in different contexts.

```
res.ui(context) /* =>
```

```
ModerationUI {  
  filter: boolean // should the content be removed from the interface?  
  blur: boolean // should the content be put behind a cover?
```

C Bluesky docs: UI contexts (contentList vs contentView vs media)

- `displayName` The user's display name in any context
- `contentList` Content being listed, e.g. posts in a feed, posts as replies, a user list list, a feed generator list, etc
- `contentView` Content being viewed direct, e.g. an opened post, the user list page, the feedgen page, etc
- `contentMedia` Media inside the content, e.g. a picture embedded in a post

Here's how a post in a feed would use these tools to make a decision:

Collection credibility (one slide)



Read-only XRPC summary

Relay + AppView reads.

GET-only in this run.

POST auth only if auth mode is used.

No posting actions.

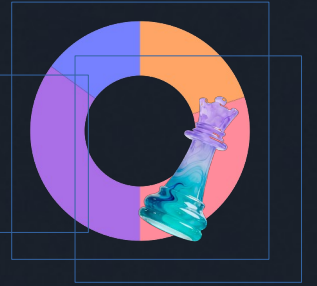
7-stage pipeline

relay -> index -> packs -> popular -> enrich -> panel
-> snapshot

Reproducibility: state.db, manifest.csv,
data_dictionary.csv, validation_report.csv.



What this enables next + advisor asks



Ready measurements

- RQ1: measure discovery concentration.
- RQ2: map provider leverage.
- RQ3: test same winner overlap.
- RQ4: compare label variability.

What I need from you

- Ask 1: priority RQs and venue fit.
- Ask 2: recollect longitudinal, auth mode, or experiments?



Bluesky UI: labeling surfaces (official)



Takeaway: labels are user-facing controls that shape what gets shown or filtered.

A. Self-label button

Composer surface

B. Content warning picker

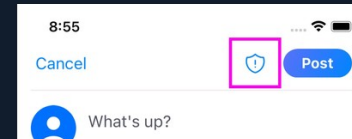
Adult Content options

C. Labeled post banner

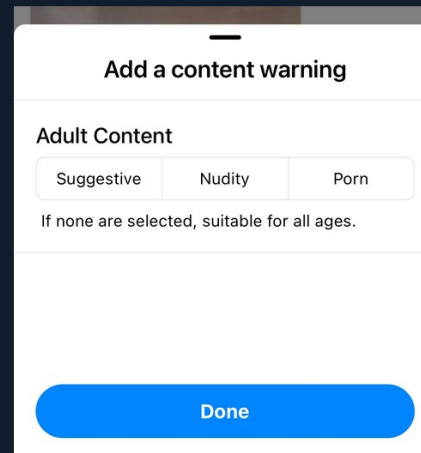
Attribution to labeler

Why it matters: filtering + exposure

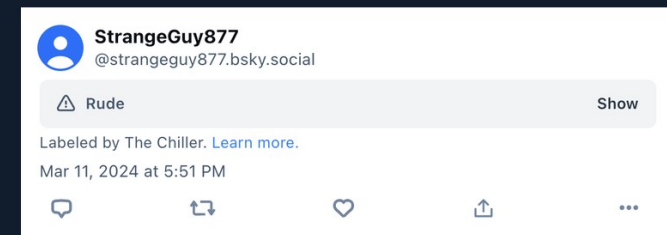
A



B



C



Bluesky UI: reply controls (official)



Takeaway: reply controls gate interaction, changing who can respond and what feedback loops

form

A. Reply controls button

Composer setting

B. Who can reply picker

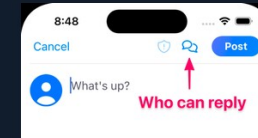
Audience gating

C. Post notice

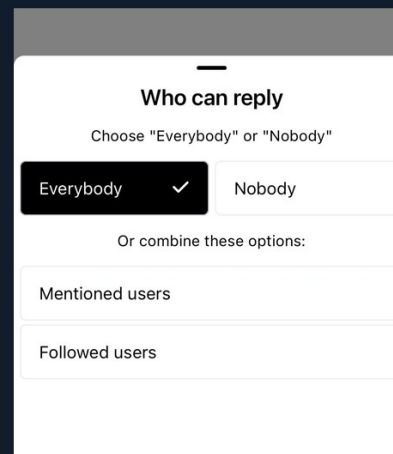
Visible constraint

Why it matters:
interaction graphs

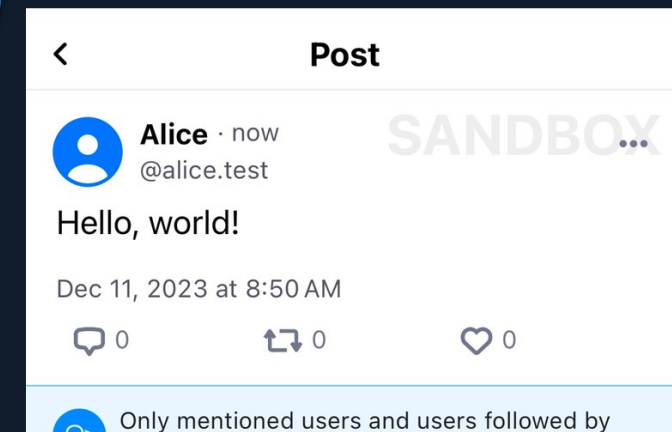
A



B



C



Bluesky UI: labelers + moderation tools (official)



Takeaway: moderation is modular—users can subscribe to labelers and tune label handling.

A. Subscribe to labeler

Third-party policies

B. Per-label controls

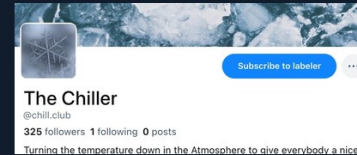
Off / Warn / Hide

C. Ozone moderation UI

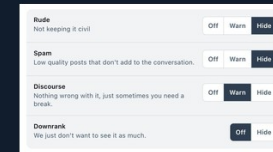
Operational tooling

Why it matters: power shifts

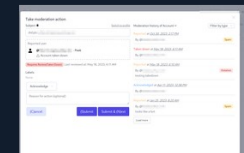
A



B



C



Bluesky UI: discovery surfaces (official)



Takeaway: discovery is shaped by navigation, defaults, and safety settings surfaced in the UI.

A. Custom feeds tab

Algorithm marketplace

B. Moderation menu

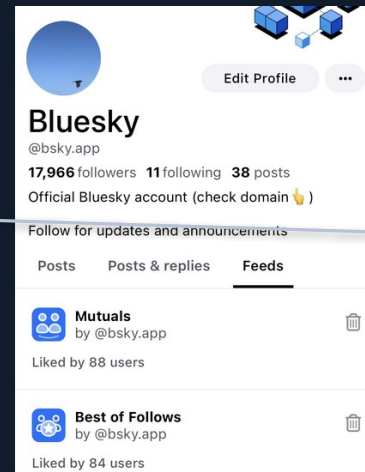
Filtering settings

C. Starter packs tab

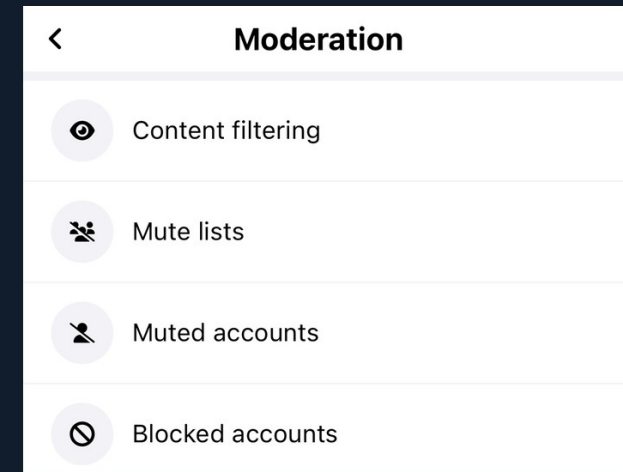
Onboarding surface

Why it matters: defaults steer

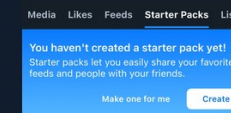
A



B



C



Bluesky UI: starter packs flow (official)



Takeaway: starter packs bundle people (and context) into a single shareable onboarding object.

A. Create starter pack

Name + description

B. Choose people

Curation choices

C. Share pack

Link / QR / image

Why it matters: bundled exposure

A

< Starter Pack

Invites, but personal

Invite your friends to follow your favorite feeds and people

What do you want to call your starter pack?

Emily's starter pack 0/50

Tell us a little more

Emily's favorite feeds and people - join me!

B

< Choose People

Search

Phil Lewis @phillewis.bsky.social

Cats of Yore @catsofyore.bsky.social

Tim Onion @bencollins.bsky.social

NPR @npr.org

Jake Tapper, long-suffering Phill... @jaketapper.bsky.social

Jon Bois @jonbois.bsky.social

june @junlper.bsky.social

C

Invite people to this starter pack!

Share this starter pack and help people join your community on Bluesky.

JOIN THE CONVERSATION

Emily's Starter Pack on Bluesky

Share link

Share QR code

Save image

Bluesky UI: domain handles (surface → settings)

(official)

Takeaway: domain handles connect identity and credibility to a verifiable control channel

(DNS)

A. Domain handle profile

Trust signal

B. Settings: handle

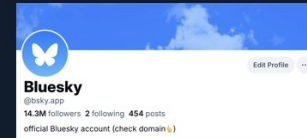
Entry point

C. Use own domain

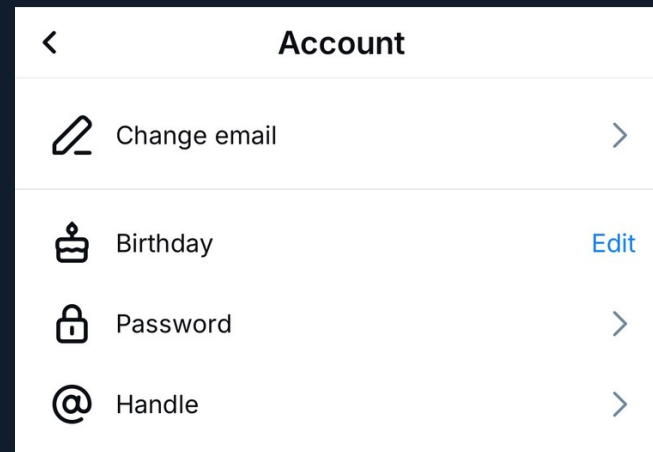
Verification flow

Why it matters: credibility

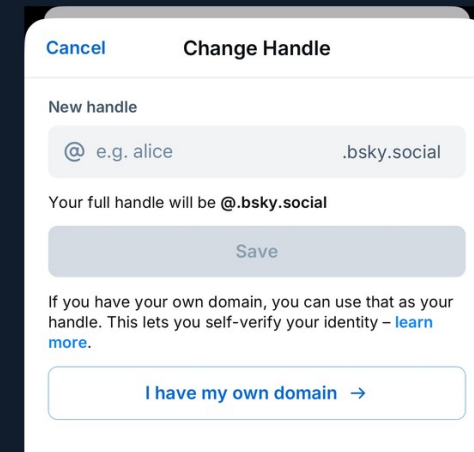
A



B



C



Bluesky UI: domain verification + examples (official)



Takeaway: verification relies on external DNS tooling, creating measurable and potentially repeatable steps

A. DNS TXT record

Proof-of-control

B. Domain handle example

@npr.org

C. DNS management UI

External dependency

Why it matters:
measurable steps

A

Cancel Change Handle

Enter the domain you want to use

@ e.g. alice.com

DNS Panel No DNS Panel

Add the following DNS record to your domain:

Host:	_atproto
Type:	TXT
Value:	did=did:plc:z72i7hdytmk6r22z27h6tvur

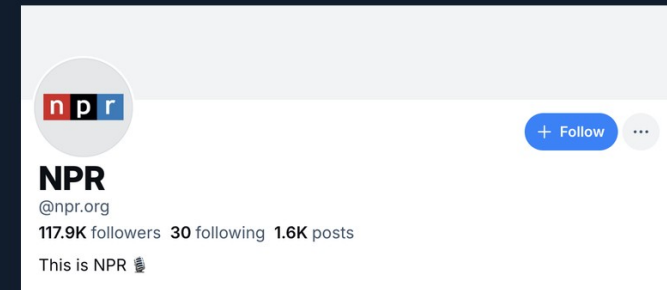
This should create a domain record at:

_atproto.

Verify DNS Record

Nevermind, create a handle for me

B



C

DNS management for atproto.com

All changes made in the edit drawer are implemented once saved.

Import and Export Dashboard Display Settings

Search DNS Records

Add filter Search Add record